Geographies of Wellbeing in Poland (Urban-Rural, Regions, and Cities)

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1 Wellbeing

The proposed study's outcome of interest is multidimensional human wellbeing or flourishing. Two key dimensions are happiness or life satisfaction[1] and freedom (agency/autonomy).[2]

Happiness is now recognized as a development goal in addition to GDP–the UN has passed resolution A/RES/65/309: "Happiness: towards a holistic approach to development" stating that "the pursuit of happiness is a fundamental human goal" and "recognizing that the gross domestic product indicator [GDP] by nature was not designed to and does not adequately reflect the happiness and well-being of people."[3]

Freedom (agency/autonomy) is a human right as stated by the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (art. 26, 29): "freedom for the realization of one's human potential." Freedom is an end-in-itself, as recognized by Fromm (2013, 2012, 1992, 1964, 1944, [1941] 1994) and Sen (2000).

There is a new geography of wellbeing field (e.g., Ballas and Dorling 2013). The field has mostly international focus across countries, with only few recent studies focusing on specific countries.[4]

Now the time is right for a geography of wellbeing study in Poland. In 2026 Poland is not very different from Western Europe anymore. Poland is a quite developed country now. Indeed, Polish PCGDP PPP[5] is now about the same as in Japan, and Polish minimum wage of 31 PLN or 8.15 USD (as of 2026) is higher than the US minimum wage at 7.25 USD.

It was not like that before, however. I remember about 10 years ago I gave a talk on happiness in Warsaw, and students didn't seem to see a need to care about happiness. Traditional topics like economic growth and personal income seemed more important.

Wellbeing is increasingly relevant as Poland has been transitioning from developing country into a developed country so quality of life and wellbeing increasingly matter over economic/survival basics such as income and unemployment in the past. When Poland was quite poor the focus rightly so was on survival and economic growth. As Poland has experienced economic miracle over past several years,[6] now it's time to focus on wellbeing. For visualization of the changing values from survival to wellbeing along with the economic growth see figure 1.

[1] We use the terms interchangeably as is the usual practice in the social indicators literature, but specifically we mean global cognitive evaluation of life as whole rather than momentary and fleeing affective happiness.

[2] Specifically we mean so called `freedom to`, not `freedom from` (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2014). Poles are `free from`: live in a free country, have no coercion, and are free from restrictions and impediments. But are they `free to`? Are Poles actually able to choose, control and direct one's own life (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2015)?

[3] See `https://docs.un.org/en/A/RES/65/309`. Also see report promoting wellbeing as a human development measure by Nobel prize laureates Sen and Stiglitz (Stiglitz et al. 2009).

[4] See next section.

[5] Per Capita Gross Domestic Product Purchasing Power Parity adjusted.

[6] For instance Warszawski Index Gieldowy (WIG) has increased about 120% over past 5 years.

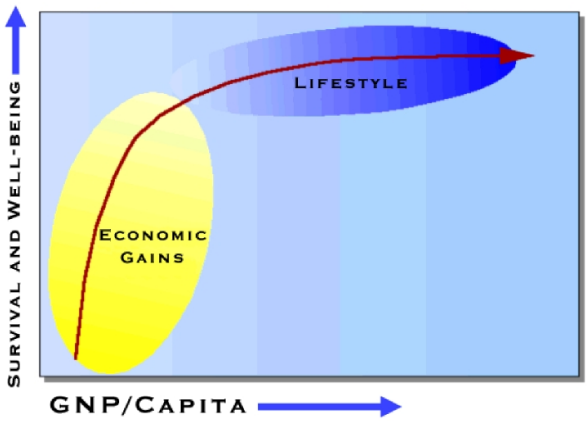


Figure 1: From survival to wellbeing as economic growth increases (Inglehart 1997).

2 Geographies: Urban-Rural, Regions, and Cities

Poland is a medium-large country, 9th both in terms of area and population in Europe,[7] and yet we know little about geographies of wellbeing in Poland and lack a dedicated comprehensive study. Hence, I propose this study to fill the gap. Poland is a diverse country in terms of its urban-rural, regional, and city geographies.

Urban-rural is not a binary, but a gradient–we will use several steps to capture this gradient. Urban-rural gradient matters a great deal, more than most scholars realize. Indeed, it is difficult to overestimate its importance–the key point is that urbanicity is not only a built environment, but a way of life (Wirth 1938).

Weckroth and Kemppainen (2021) is a closely related study to our proposed study–they analyze SWB by urban-rural using ESS in Europe–we will also use ESS among other datasets, but focus on Poland and add more recent waves and more wellbeing indicators. Knies (2026) is another close ESS study[8] –it uses multiple indicators, but only one wave 6 and like other research does not focus on Poland. There are no studies on urban-rural freedom gradient, not just in Poland but anywhere–ours is the first.[9] Next we turn to regions.

Regions are an useful level of analysis as there are great differences within countries and across regions, and Poland is no exception. There are life satisfaction studies across regions, but no study focuses on Poland (e.g., Okulicz-Kozaryn 2011, Ballas and Rijnks 2023, Ziogas et al. 2023, 2020). Similarly, quality of life and wellbeing studies across regions and cities focus on cross-country patterns, not Poland, and tend to use older datasets (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2019, Okulicz-Kozaryn 2013). Poland has 16 voivodeships, so called NUTS2 level regions.[10] At NUTS2 level we will investigate geographic clustering and the relationship between objective development measures such as income and subjective measures (SWB). There are also interesting population dynamics at NUTS2 level, for instance, Mazovia (where Warsaw is located) has been growing, but most other regions have been stable or shrinking. We will investigate the effect of population change on wellbeing–we know that population dynamics are highly correlated with SWB (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2024), but again, we do not know the relationship in Poland.

Finally, we have data representative of Bialystok, Gdansk, Cracow, and Warsaw with domain satisfactions (life, place, personal, and financial), and various quality of life indicators regarding amenities (e.g., public goods and services such as parks) and disamenities

[7] See `unstats.un.org` and `https://population.un.org`.

[8] And there are 2 more ESS studies: Ivanovic et al. (2022) is an urban-rural study, but again only 2 waves and no focus on Poland. Vaznonienė and Jarašiūnaitė-Fedosejeva (2019) is interesting ESS study in a sense that it does focus on one country and discusses country specific intricacies like us, but it is Lithuania. Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2021) is a major recent study using WVS, but as most research it focuses on cross-country patterns, not Poland.

[9] Yamagishi et al. (2012) studies urban-rural freedom but in very different way from us–they show that urbanites are more likely to chose extravagant pens than rural folks. We will study freedom for urban-rural and regions (we do not have freedom variable for cities).

[10] Voivodeships=NUTS2, except Mazowieckie (the Warsaw region)–1 single voivodeship, but 2 NUTS2: Warsaw Metropolitan and Mazovian Region; so total of 17 NUTS2 regions.

(e.g., community problems such as crime). We will investigate these across the cities. Specifically, large Warsaw (and perhaps Cracow) is likely to differ from small Bialystok. Warsaw stands out as not only the largest city, but also possibly a primate city, disproportionately larger and more influential than any other city.[11]

Last but not least, there are several related Polish studies in smaller local journals that are worth mentioning as they are mostly about Poland specifically–again, the international literature tends not to focus on Poland. Sompolska-Rzechuła and Kurdyś-Kujawska (2020) is quite close, but uses different data: Polish Social Diagnosis dataset and does not control for SWB predictors. Vaznonienė and Wojewódzka-Wiewiórska (2021) uses ESS and studies urban-rural SWB like us, but focuses on Lithuania v Poland, and uses waves 4 and 9 only and 3 urbanicity categories only, and does not control for SWB predictors. Wojewódzka-Wiewiórska and Dudek (2023) is the same, just uses waves 2 and 8. Tobiasz-Adamczyk and Zawisza (2017) does the analyses across the regions and urban-rural, but their sample is elderly and the study is about health only. Stangierska et al. (2022) studies quality of life across green v not green urban areas, but only across Warsaw neighborhoods, and the sample size is small at 381 persons. Sompolska-Rzechuła and Kurdyś-Kujawska (2021) uses Polish Social Diagnosis and studies urban-rural SWB–but separately: predictors of SWB in urban separately from predictors of SWB in rural. Overall, while there are studies focusing on Poland, like our proposed study, they have important limitations as summarized above.[12] Hence, we know little about wellbeing geographies in Poland–we turn to our, yet un-answered, hypotheses.

3 Hypotheses

H_1 Cities have lower multidimensional Subjective Wellbeing (SWB) than rural areas, with the largest drop occurring for the largest places. [WVS, ESS, FB539][13]

H_1a Certain social groups such as working-age adults and higher social classes have higher SWB in cities v rural areas. [WVS, ESS]

H_1b Over time, from 1989 to 2012, the SWB gap between cities and rural places has increased. [WVS]

H_2 More remote, less populated, and lower density regions have higher SWB than more central, more populated and higher density regions. [ESS, FB539]

H_2a Regions that experienced population growth will have higher SWB than flat or shrinking regions. [ESS, FB539]

H_2b Across regions correlation between objective quality of life measures such as income with SWB measures will be moderate only at < 0.5 thus revealing inadequacy of traditional progress/development measures such as income. [ESS, FB539]

H_2c Urban-rural happiness gradient across regions will be relatively stable, i.e., larger places have higher SWB than smaller places. [ESS, FB539]

H_3 The relationship between quality of life (local amenities and disamenities) and domain satisfactions (life, place, personal, and financial) will differ across Bialystok, Gdansk, Cracow, and Warsaw. [FB366,419]

4 Data and Measurement

The goal is to do a comprehensive study of Polish geographies of wellbeing, hence we use multiple datasets, each having its own strengths: World Values Survey (WVS), European Social Survey (ESS), and Flash Barometers (FB) for regions (FB539) and cities

[11] At $> 3m$ Warsaw metro is larger than Katowice metro at about 2.5m and third Karkow metro at 1.5m. While Katowice metro is not half or less of Warsaw metro as "the law of the primate city" would indicate (see discussion in Berry and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2012), it is only due to the location of Katowice in regional industrial cluster (Gornoslaski Okreg Przemyslowy (GOP)), Katowice city itself is much smaller than Warsaw at 0.28m v 1.9m. Maybe Warsaw is not such clear primate as Cairo (Mikhaeil et al. 2024), but it could be similar in its primate status to Bogota (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2026).

[12] And there are several studies that differ from the above. Churski and Perdał (2022) has very fine geographical resolution of 380 units across Poland, but they do not study SWB, only the related objective indicators such as jobs. Weziak-Bialowolska et al. (2025) is one of the very many of the studies co-authored with VanderWeele, this time in Poland, but there is no geography in the study. Wkeziak-Bialowolska (2016) uses the same flash barometer 366 that we will use, but does not focus on Poland and instead on all European cities.

[13] WVS=World Values Survey; ESS=European Social Survey; FB539=Flash Barometer #539–these and other datasets are described in the next section.

(FB366,419).

WVS has a usual SWB item: "All things considered, how satisfied are you with your life as a whole these days?" on scale 1-10. Such SWB measures tend to be reasonably valid and reliable (Diener 2009, ch. 5). WVS allows us to examine the geographies of wellbeing over time, which is important as Poland has evolved greatly, and WVS data goes back to 1989. We have 4k observations, about 1k per wave.[14] Also, an important advantage of WVS is that urbanicity is recorded by an interviewer.[15]

Freedom is measured in WVS,[16] and in some ESS waves containing a whole battery of wellbeing items measuring functionings and vitality. Preliminary analyses using ESS 1-6 cumulative file already had over 10k observations for Poland.[17] We will use ESS items such as those in wave 6 on functioning "free to decide how to live my life," and vitality "had lot of energy."[18]

FB539 (2024) has 5.2k observations and is representative of 17 NUTS2 regions, and has a usual SWB question similar to WVS.[19] FB366,419 (2012, 2015) are representative of 4 Polish cities: Bialystok, Gdansk, Cracow, and Warsaw. The sample size is about 2000 observations per wave, and again we have a usual SWB question like in WVS.

5 Models

We will mostly use ordinary least squares (OLS).[20] For robustness/sensitivity checks for the key models we will use multinomial logit (as the ordinal logit tends to fail proportional odds assumption). As another robustness/sensitivity check we are considering machine learning models such as gradient boosting models (Oparina et al. 2025), specifically XGBoost (`https://xgboost.readthedocs.io`).

We will use a usual set of controls such as those in the literature: for life satisfaction (e.g., Berry and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2009, Okulicz-Kozaryn 2010); and for freedom (e.g., Pitlik 2016, Nikolaev and Bennett 2016). A key robustness/sensitivity check will be specification curve analysis (SCA) (Simonsohn et al. 2020). And we will pay extra attention to the choice of control variables and avoid overcontrol bias.[21]

To examine geographic patterns among regions we will use choropleth maps, Moran's I, and Local Indicators of Spatial Association (LISA) (Anselin 1995).[22]

[14] We use waves 1989, 1997, 2005, and 2012. For the 1997, 2005, and 2012 waves we have 8 rural-urban categories -2k, 2-5k, 5-10k, 10-20k, 20-50k, 50-100k, 100-500k, and 500k-. In 1989 we only have information about 49 voivodeships, but urbanicity can be inferred from this information indirectly, and proximity to a major city directly.

[15] It is more objective than subjective respondent self-reports. For instance, respondents may not know well whether they live in a 20k or 30k place.

[16] "Some people feel they have completely free choice and control over their lives, while other people feel that what they do has no real effect on what happens to them. Please use this scale where 1 means 'none at all' and 10 means 'a great deal' to indicate how much freedom of choice and control you feel you have over the way your life turns out." Validity and reliability of the measure seem fine and the variable has been used successfully in the literature (e.g., Verme 2009, Inglehart et al. 2008, Veenhoven 2000, Okulicz-Kozaryn 2014).

[17] The data will be updated upto wave 12 that will be available in 2027.

[18] ESS urbanicity is measured with: a big city, suburbs or outskirts of big city, town or small city, country village, farm or home in countryside. Per wellbeing see overview at `https://www.europeansocialsurvey.org/findings/europeans-wellbeing/measuring-wellbeing`. Wave 6 wellbeing items: `https://europeansocialsurvey.org/sites/default/files/2026-01/ESS12-wellbeing-module-design-template.pdf` see Table 1: Items from the well-being module grouped by the dimension of wellbeing they relate to. We also will use new wave 12 that will be available in 2027 and will contain a wellbeing module. See `https://europeansocialsurvey.org/sites/default/files/2026-01/ESS12-wellbeing-module-design-template.pdf`.

[19] We may also use the earlier flash barometers: #497 (2021), #472 (2018), #427 (2015), #356 (2012) depending on how strong and robust the latest wave results are.

[20] Although OLS assumes cardinality of the outcome variable, and SWB measures are technically ordinal, OLS is an appropriate estimation method. Ferrer-i-Carbonell and Frijters (2004) has shown that OLS results are substantially the same as those from discrete models, and OLS has become the default method in happiness research (Blanchflower and Oswald 2011). Theoretically, while there is still debate about the cardinality of SWB, there are strong arguments to treat it as a cardinal variable (Ng 1996, 1997, 2011).

[21] "What we really need, to identify/estimate X$->$Y, is to control for other determinants of Y that are also antecedents of X (so, W$->$X). If we include controls where the relationship goes the other way (X$->$W), we will exacerbate bias in our estimate of X$->$Y. (The relevant term for that situation is 'overcontrol bias')" (Bartram et al. 2024, p. 5).

[22] We may do some multilevel modeling (MLM) at NUTS2 level as in Weckroth and Kemppainen (2021) but focusing on Poland. Yet MLM is problematic with only 17 U/As at Level 2–if we use it, results will be postponed to appendix. We may use Small Area Estimation (Moretti and Ahmed 2024).

6 Significance, Policy, and Practice

The proposed research will contribute to the literature and produce new knowledge. We will write several papers in this project, and through further research mentoring and leadership additional ones.

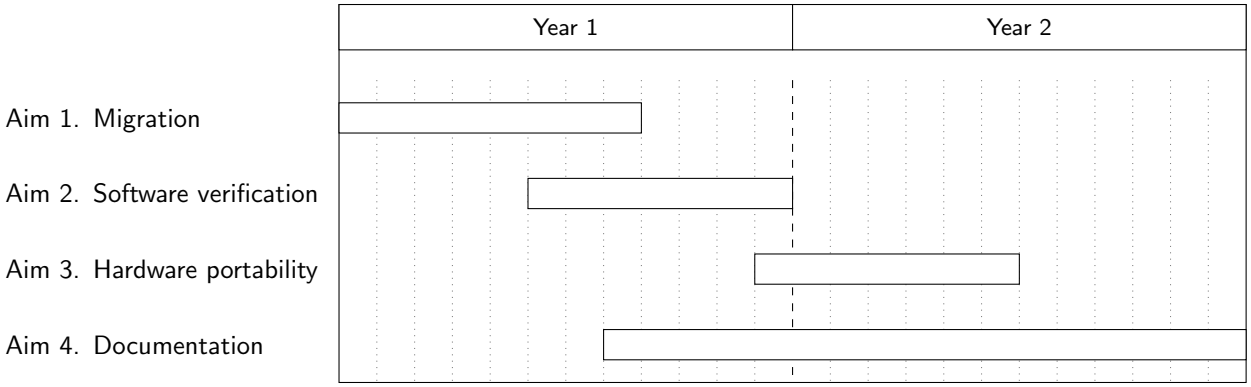
But the research also has policy and practical implications. First, as stated in the introduction, the time has come for Poles to focus on wellbeing as opposed to just survival. We have modernized infrastructure, higher incomes, and booming economy. The focus on survival and economy can now give a way to wellbeing and flourishing. With the proposed study we aim to aid in this pursuit of happiness. This is called evidence-based pursuit of happiness in the literature (Veenhoven 2012).[23] The proposed study will find out which parts of Poland enjoy high wellbeing and for whom–which social groups, e.g., by age and social class, flourish where? Our findings should help Poles increase their wellbeing.

SWB can and should be used for public policy and administration (Diener 2009). SWB can serve as a "yardstick" (Veenhoven 1988)–arguably the ultimate outcome of public policy and administration is SWB.[24] "If you can't measure it, you can't improve it"–if governments don't measure wellbeing, they can't improve wellbeing. I will reach out to Polish government to implement the study findings in practice. I plan to start locally with Wielkopolska voivodeship, where I will be physically carrying out the study, and other regional governments may be involved as well. Likewise, some city governments may be involved as the study will use data representative of 4 cities.

There are many avenues for specific policy and practice collaborations. One simple implementation is simply to educate policy makers, public administrators, and citizenry about the wellbeing metrics and study's findings so that we can make more informed decisions.

It is relatively straightforward to implement the study's findings. For instance, we will find where and which social groups flourish and languish–such information can be then used to advance utilitarianism, produce the "greatest happiness for the greatest number" (Akay et al. 2015, Nussbaum 2012, Kahneman et al. 1997). Another avenue is to use the wellbeing metrics to evaluate policy. For instance, if there a major change in policy or investment in public goods, we can actually measure whether it produced an increase in wellbeing by using before-after comparative group research design (difference-in-difference). Finally, it could be data collection, say implementing a survey similar to Flash Barometers locally; or using social media data to meeasure wellbeing (Iacus et al. 2025).

7 plan



[23] There is a psychological nuance here–one should not focus fully on the pursuit of happiness and chase it or value it intensely (Mauss et al. 2011, Gruber et al. 2011), neither be concerned about it and judge it (Zerwas et al. 2024)–it may backfire. Rather, one needs to know what is important for wellbeing from the academic literature, like the proposed study, and include this information in everyday decision-making. For instance, humans should buy experience such as travel and time with others, not things such as conspicuous consumption items (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Tursi 2015, Veblen 2005a,b, Thoreau 1995 [1854]).

[24] While the idea of using wellbeing data for policy and administration is new in Poland, it is not new in general (Stiglitz et al. 2009, Diener 2009).

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